

Good Neighbors

Leon and Randy had lived next door to each other for forty years. During that time, they shared more than friendship. They shared their yards. Leon had one of the most diverse collections of azaleas in the world. And Randy was a renowned beekeeper, whose honey regularly won prizes. His secret was the careful location of his hives, placed strategically near choice vegetation and, of course, near Leon's azaleas. Importantly, Randy took great care to ensure that the hives had a clear view of the sky, so that their bees would easily be able to orient themselves.



When Leon died, his house and yard were sold to a developer, Harkins, who tore out the azaleas and leveled the yard. His plan was to install a swimming pool and sell the house as a suburban oasis. The county, however, demanded that he build a wall around the yard, which was a problem, because the pool Harkins planned barely fit in the yard. So he approached Randy, offering to buy three feet of his land at the boundary, telling him that he was obsessed with making the yard symmetrical. He made no mention of the pool or the wall. For a while, Randy could not think clearly about the proposition -- he was distraught at the loss of his friend and by the loss of the azaleas. But as he observed heavy equipment in Leon's old yard, Randy finally understood what Harkins was up to. He angrily rejected Harkins' offer, realizing that the developer was trying to wall the pool over his hives.